

What should I believe?

If you think about it, our initial question really breaks down into two sub-questions.

When should I form a
new belief?

When should I discard
one of my beliefs?

Positive rules of belief will tell you
when you should form a certain
belief.

If you are in such-and-such
circumstances, you should
believe P.

Negative rules of belief will tell you
when you should not have a certain
belief.

If you are in such-and-such
circumstances, you should not
believe P.

It might at first seem extremely easy to formulate the rules of belief. The following would seem to be plausible candidates, respectively, for positive and negative rules of belief.

If P is true, you should
believe P .

If P is not true, you should
not believe P .

The problem with these rules of belief is not that they are incorrect; the problem is that in many cases they won't be of much practical use, since in many cases we don't know for sure whether the claim in question is true or false. (If we did, there would be no serious question about whether to form the belief.)

TRUTH → BELIEF

NO TRUTH → NO BELIEF

We'll be trying, for the next three classes, to improve upon these two rules by trying to formulate rules of belief which we could actually put to use.

Why would we want to do this? We all face cases where it is not clear what we should believe. In fact, you might think, philosophy is a kind of machine for generating hard cases! Haven't we already seen lots of cases in which there are arguments on both sides of an issue, and where it is hard to tell which argument is better?

Here is a hard case of interest:

The Believer

I've always believed that there is a God. I never really thought about what my evidence is for this claim. But now I wonder whether I have good reason for my beliefs. Some of the arguments for God's existence sound good, but all face objections that I am not sure how to answer. Still, I continue to believe that God exists.

It is genuinely hard to know what to do in this kind of situation. And it is hard to see how to figure it out other than by trying to figure out what the rules of belief are.

Today we're going to focus on the question,

When should I discard
one of my beliefs?

This is a question which most people face at some point in their lives. Often, people face it in an especially sharp way at exactly the age you are now. Going to college, where you encounter new ideas and new people, is a natural time to wonder whether you still really accept the views that you used to believe.

“Some years ago I was struck by the large number of falsehoods which I had accepted as true in my childhood, and by the highly doubtful nature of the whole edifice that I had subsequently based on them. I realized that it was necessary, once in the course of my life, to demolish everything completely and start again right from the foundations if I wanted to establish anything at all ... that was stable and likely to last.”

Descartes gave a famous statement of this idea:

Your system of beliefs is like a web. Once you form a new belief, that belief typically combines with your other beliefs to give you yet more beliefs. So forming even one belief which you should not form is likely to lead to a whole series of mistakes.

Descartes' thought is that the only way to fix this situation is to re-examine your beliefs once you are an adult, and see if there are any that you should discard.

That leads to the question: what rule should you use to tell you which to discard?

Here again Descartes gives us an answer.

“Reason now leads me to believe that I should hold back my assent from opinions which are not completely certain and indubitable just as carefully as I do from those which are patently false. So, for the purpose of rejecting my opinions, it will be enough if I find in each of them some reason for doubt.”

What would it mean for you to find in someone belief a reason for doubt?

It seems that to find a reason for doubting a belief would be to be less than certain that the belief is true. But what things can we be certain of?

One natural thought is that we can be certain only of those things that
we can **prove**. This suggests the following rule of belief:

But it looks like this process is never going to end. So one of two things is going to have to be true.

The first option is that I have to simply keep on constructing new arguments, with new previously un-used premises. But because this process is never going to end — since I have to prove all of my beliefs — it looks like I will have to provide infinitely many arguments. But that is impossible, at least for beings like us!

The second option is that I can re-use some of the claims I was trying to prove as premises in my arguments, so that the process goes in a circle. So maybe P is used to argue for Q , and Q is used to argue for R , and R is used to argue for P . But it does not seem as though this sort of circular reasoning can be a good reason to form a belief.

No Good Argument $\rightarrow$ No Belief

If you can't give a good
argument for P, don't believe P.

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